

On the first two days of its release, Hungama servers crashed for 37 minutes as users tried to download content. And over 15,000 people watched his movie in Chennai on the first day alone. All this while his previous movie, *Chandramukhi*, for which he was paid Rs 15 crore, the combined pay of Bollywood's top five heroes, is still running in theatres—as of June 25, it was the 804th day. So what exactly explains the Rajnikant phenomenon? How can a man transcend entertainment to become an experience? Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi says it is because of his humility, while Romesh Sharma, the director who cast him in *Hum*, 1991, believes it is because he is the *aam aadmi ka aam aadmi*—the common man's common man, whose goodness has snowballed. While his charities extend from schools to organising free weddings, his wife, Latha, also runs The Ashram, a well regarded school in Chennai. His one-time *Hum* co-star and the man whom he is most often compared to, Amitabh Bachchan, thinks it is because he is a great human being. As S.P. Muthuraman, who gave the actor his first hero role in *Bhuvana oru Kelvikkuri*, 1977, and has directed him in 25 films, says: "I have been with him for the past 32 years. He hasn't changed from the day I met him."

Perhaps he has only become more generous. When his film *Baba*, 2002, was a failure, he returned the advance—Rs 10 crore—to the distributors of the movie. When Sivaji

Productions was in trouble, he agreed to do *Chandramukhi* for them. When veteran actor Panadari Bhai, who played his mother in *Mannan*, was in financial trouble, he bailed her out. And when Manorama, a character-actor, faced ostracism in the Tamil film industry because of her comments on his "drinking habit", he gave her a role in his film *Arunachalam*.

More than that, in this age of maintaining facades, the Lord Raghavendra devotee is happy to step out of his Poes Garden home without a wig—his looks are something he is ready to laugh at, as shown in the Fair and Lovely sequence in *Sivaji*. His 20-day annual incognito trips to the Himalayas are

Baba... enthapakkamum sayatha baba (Baba ... never takes sides)

Baba, 2002

legendary but what is lesser known is the fact that he often takes off to New York, eating out at expensive places and staying in posh hotels. What makes him a star though is his work ethic. "After a shot is canned, he doesn't retire to his van. He stays at the shooting spot and leaves only when I say pack up. When I wanted him to tussle his head for the movie, he didn't even blink," says *Sivaji* director Shankar, adding that when he asked the superstar to shave his moustache for a shot in the Telugu version of *Sivaji*, Rajnikant agreed even though he had second thoughts earlier.

So what is it that explains his universal appeal? Movie analyst Charu

Aandavan solran ...Arunachalam mudikkiran (God orders....Arunachalam executes)

Arunachalam, 1997



H K RAJASHEKAR

